

The homeschool portfolio checklist

Whatever your state asks for, a good portfolio answers the same question: what did this child actually learn this year? Collect as you go — reconstructing it in April is miserable.

Check your own state first. Requirements vary enormously — some states want an annual assessment and a reviewer, some want nothing at all. This is a general working checklist, not legal advice.

THE RECORDS

- | | |
|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Attendance / days log
Dated, kept as you go. A record written months later is worth less. ☐ Instructional hours log
Where your state counts hours rather than days. ☐ Subjects covered, per child ☐ Curriculum or materials list
Titles and publishers, not just "maths". | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Reading log
Often the most impressive single document in the file. ☐ Standardised test or assessment results
If required where you are. ☐ Letter of intent / notice of intent
Filed copy, with the date sent. |
|--|--|

THE WORK SAMPLES

- | | |
|---|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Three to five samples per subject
Beginning, middle and end of year shows growth better than perfect pieces. ☐ At least one piece of long-form writing ☐ Maths work showing method, not just answers | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ A science experiment or project write-up ☐ Photographs of hands-on and physical work
Build projects, art, experiments, field trips. ☐ One thing the child chose themselves
Interest-led work is worth including deliberately. |
|---|--|

THE CONTEXT

- | | |
|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Field trips and where you went ☐ Co-op, class or group participation ☐ Sports, music, clubs and volunteering ☐ Life skills and practical work
Cooking, budgeting, caring for animals — it counts as learning. | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ A short summary per subject
Three or four sentences on what was covered and how it went. ☐ Goals for next year
Useful for you, and it reads well to a reviewer. |
|--|--|

HOW TO KEEP IT PAINLESS

- | | |
|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Photograph work the day it is finished
A dated photo beats a shoebox in June. ☐ One folder per child, per year ☐ Log hours the same day
Two minutes daily beats a weekend of reconstruction. | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> ☐ Keep the reading log where the reading happens ☐ Do a ten-minute tidy each month
Twelve short sessions instead of one long panic. ☐ Back it up
A portfolio that lives on one device is one spill away from gone. |
|---|---|

WHAT A REVIEWER IS ACTUALLY LOOKING FOR

Not perfection. Reviewers are checking that instruction happened, that it covered the required areas, and that the child moved forward. Growth beats polish every time — a wobbly first attempt next to a confident later one tells the story better than two

flawless worksheets.

☐ **Evidence of progress over time**

Same subject, early and late. This is the single most persuasive thing in a portfolio.

☐ **Coverage of the required subject areas**

Check your state list and make sure nothing is missing entirely.

☐ **Consistency with your hours or days log**

The samples should look like the amount of time you recorded.

☐ **The child's own voice**

Work they chose, questions they asked, things they made unprompted.

☐ **Your summaries**

A few sentences per subject does more than another twenty worksheets.

IF YOU ONLY KEEP FIVE THINGS

☐ The attendance or hours log

☐ The reading log

☐ One dated writing sample per term

☐ Maths work showing method

☐ Photographs of everything physical

Using this with the **HavenKept Homeschool Planner: Attendance & Hours** logs the days and hours, **Subjects & Grades** and **Lessons** hold what was covered, **Record Keeping** and **Portfolio** gather it together, and **Progress & Reports** prints or exports to PDF when someone asks to see it.